

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | WEDNESDAY, JUNE 3, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

'BROADVIEW SIX' CASE

Boutros appeared at grand jury

US attorney acknowledges contact the day before indictment handed up in October

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros released a startling report Tuesday acknowledging he appeared before the grand jury in the "Broadview Six" case on the day the indictment was handed up in October, asking for those on the panel who could not keep an open mind on immigration evidence to "please raise your hand."

INSIDE: U.S. Senators Durbin and Duckworth demand Boutros resign. **Chicagoland, Page A4**

Boutros' rare Oct. 23 appearance at the grand jury came at the height of Operation Midway Blitz and was an attempt to quell discord after a prosecutor had dismissed at least two panel members who had personal issues with the case and refused to deliberate. A previ-

ous panel, in fact, had declined to indict at all — issuing a rare "no bill" instead.

It's unusual for a sitting U.S. attorney to personally appear before any grand jury, but for Boutros to have done so in such a controversial case is sure to fuel allegations of undue pressure to return an indictment.

"Of all days for the U.S. Attorney to make a rare appearance before the grand jury, that he would be present on the day he likely knew

this case would be re-presented speaks for itself," attorney Christopher Parente, who represents one of the former Broadview defendants, said in a written statement Tuesday.

In his five-page report, however, Boutros defended his appearance before the grand jury, saying its importance "cannot be overstated" given the animosity and bias that had shown itself in previous grand

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U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros, at Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on April 3. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE**



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Swimmer sculptures make a splash

Quan is one of a series of swimmer sculptures by artist Carole Feuerman that were installed Tuesday along North Michigan Avenue in Chicago. Ten displays in the outdoor art exhibit will line the Magnificent Mile through November. **Arts & Living, Page B8**

President taps Pulte to lead national intelligence

Housing regulator to maintain duties in temporary position

By Josh Boak
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump has tapped Bill Pulte, head of the Federal Housing Finance Agency, to be the acting director of national intelligence — elevating a real estate scion without any clear national security credentials to a key post as the U.S. remains at war with Iran.

Trump made the surprise announcement Tuesday on social media that Pulte would be replacing Tulsi Gabbard, the former U.S. House Democrat from Hawaii who had served as the director of national intelligence. Trump said Pulte will keep his other positions even as he fills in for Gabbard, who resigned last month after revealing her husband's cancer diagnosis.

The Republican president cited Pulte's work at the FHFA and his role as chair of the mortgage giants Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac as indicating that his real estate work would overlap with the

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Yadira Escamilla at her church, Unity Fellowship Missionary Baptist Church, in Chicago's Austin neighborhood on Tuesday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

'HOUSE OF HORRORS'

Woman alleges rampant abuse overlooked at foster facility in lawsuit

By Rebecca Johnson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Yadira Escamilla was sent to stay in the basement inside a South Side foster facility she in some ways lost touch with the outside world.

She was separated from other teens who stayed on the upper floors, she said. Her room was tiny, with only space for a couch, bed and dresser.

There were no windows. And crucially, no security cameras.

"It was scary because I didn't really have any more access to anybody," Escamilla told the Tribune. "I was just locked there downstairs."

That room was where an overnight manager for the first time physically restrained and sexually assaulted the then-17-year-old, a lawsuit filed last week in Cook County Circuit

Court said.

Escamilla alleges in the suit against Aunt Martha's Health and Wellness, the nonprofit that operated the now-closed residential facility, and its security contractor, A-Alert Security Services, that they failed to protect her from repeated sexual abuse and grooming in early 2024 despite "obvious

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Group battling illegal dumping

Litter Caterpillars try to maintain Englewood community garden

By Christiana Freitag
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When David Bippes recently brought his parents to see a small plot of land tucked between a raised railway track and a row of homes in Englewood, he was hoping to show them his latest community project.

Bippes, an Eagle Scout whose passion for community gardens began with a high school service project in Missouri, now helps lead Litter Caterpillars, a Chicago volunteer cleanup organization. Last year, he and three other group leaders purchased the formerly vacant lot through a citywide land auction, hoping to transform it into a neighborhood green space.

"It's like extending a childhood project," Bippes said.

The group converted the 6,000-square-foot lot into a small park with mulch, raised garden beds for tomatoes and native Illinois plants, including prairie grasses and yellow coneflowers, and celebrated the opening April 12.

But when Bippes arrived with his parents a week later, they found 3- and 5-foot-high piles of landscaping debris dumped across the property. One mound blocked the sidewalk bordering the park.

"We're trying to reduce litter, not increase litter," he said.

Co-founders Bippes and Kevin Tao said they don't know who left the debris or when it was dumped, but the incidents have complicated efforts to build trust and encourage community investment — something both say is critical to the park's long-term survival.

Since the park's opening, the group has struggled with repeated illegal dumping at the site, its

See **DUMPING** on Page A2

INSIDE

Family restaurants span generations

Tufano's Vernon Park Tap in Little Italy and Sun Wah BBQ on the North Side are in different parts of the city and serve cuisines from different parts of the world. Both began with immigrant families who wanted to share the food they grew up with while building a life in Chicago. **Food & Health**

Will the White Sox spend to contend?

With the White Sox surprising experts, will Jerry Reinsdorf spend at the trade deadline? **Sports**

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